

4 DAYS IN KOH SAMUI

The complete local plan · extended edition

The full island in four days — north, west, south and the east coast — from someone who lives here.

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I live on Koh Samui, and this is the extended version of the route I give friends flying in from Europe — four days instead of three, so you get the whole island. Days one to three loop the north, quiet west coast and wild south; day four covers the east coast and Chaweng, the busy tourist side, with my honest take on what's actually worth your time there and what to skip. Move through it in order and you'll never double back across the island.

Day 1 North & Bophut	Day 2 West coast	Day 3 South & Lamai	Day 4 East & Chaweng
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DAY 1

North coast & Bophut

Wat Plai Laem & Big Buddha

MORNING

Start with the island's two signature temples. Wat Plai Laem is built around a lake with a striking white 18-armed Guanyin goddess; a two-minute drive away, Wat Phra Yai (Big Buddha) is a 12-metre gold statue on its own little island. Both are free.

Local tip: Go before ~9am to beat the heat and tour buses. Cover shoulders and knees or you won't get in.

Capybara Coffee Samui

LATE MORNING

A slow, only-in-Thailand midday stop near Bophut: iced coffee while you hang out with capybaras and other gentle animals. Weirdly calming, and a favourite with kids.

Local tip: Slots book up — pop in first to reserve your time, then drive over to Big Buddha and come back when your slot starts.

Fisherman's Village, Bophut

AFTERNOON

Restored old-town lanes right on the water: wooden shophouses, boutiques, coffee stops and waterfront restaurants. Easy to wander for a couple of hours before dinner.

Local tip: If it's a Friday, the Walking Street night market takes over these same lanes.

Coco Tam's fire show

EVENING

End on the beach at Coco Tam's, a candle-lit bar right in Fisherman's Village. Grab a swing seat, order a drink in a coconut, and watch the nightly fire show over the water (usually around 7:15pm and again later).

Local tip: Come before sunset to claim a beanbag or swing on the sand — the front row fills fast.

DAY 2

The quiet west coast

Organic farm & coffee shop

MORNING

Start slow in the green hills inland with island-grown coffee and a proper breakfast away from the beach crowds — the side of Samui most visitors never see.

Local tip: This is your calm morning; don't rush it. The rest of day two is relaxed.

Dusit Dheva Cultural Center

LATE MORNING

A beautifully carved cultural centre celebrating Thai, Lao, Burmese and Indonesian art and mythology. Small, atmospheric, and genuinely interesting — ask about the personal tours and the Thai cooking class.

Local tip: Great option if there's a cloudy hour; it's mostly shaded and indoor.

Horse riding on the beach (Fisherman Horse Riding Samui)

AFTERNOON

The calm west-coast shallows are perfect for a ride along the water — one of the few places on the island you can do this with the sea right beside you. Book through Fisherman Horse Riding Samui.

Local tip: Book the late-afternoon slot so you finish as the light turns golden.

Sunset at Alchemy Café (Lipa Noi)

EVENING

Finish at Alchemy Café on Lipa Noi — the flattest, calmest water on Samui and the best west-facing sunset on the island. This is where locals come to watch the day end.

Local tip: Bring a drink and stay past the actual sunset — the afterglow here is the best part.